

Shaping the Urban Environment

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Affordable Housing or Public Space:

A Case Study on Elizabeth Street Garden

On May 10, 2024, while riding a Citi Bike down Elizabeth Street in Little Italy, I caught sight of an intriguing open garden bathed in the warm glow of the sunset. Though captivated, I decided not to stop for a closer look. Three months later, upon returning to New York after traveling, I remembered the spot and resolved to explore it. On August 25, 2024, I entered the



garden and immediately noticed a banner on my left reading, “Help Save the Garden.” Scanning the QR code beside it, I unknowingly embarked on a journey to uncover the challenges facing this unique space. A flyer at the site explained that the garden is kept open to the public by neighborhood volunteers, offering hundreds of free community programs across its 20,000 square feet of green space and ornamental sculptures.

After learning more about the functions of community boards and its advisory role in the society, I decide to go to Community board 2 to dive more deeply into the subject. On September 12th, 2024, after registering through the community Board No. 2’s official website, I went to a routine meeting featuring Landmarks Committee 1.

Community Board 2 (CB2) addresses key concerns related to development, planning, land use, and zoning, as well as the delivery of essential City services like sanitation and street upkeep. (*Manhattan Community Board 2*, n.d.) Located at 3 Washington Square Village, CB2 covers places including Greenwich Village, Little Italy, SoHo, NoHo, Hudson Square, Chinatown, Gansevoort Market, and of course, Elizabeth Street Garden.

Arriving early at CB2's office, I also met Mark Diller, the district manager. After a short self-introduction of myself and my interest in researching more about Elizabeth Street Garden, he told me that this meeting features entirely on the Landmarks Preservation Committee, or LPC. Also, he introduced me to a lady named Jeannine Kiely, who is the president of "Friends of Elizabeth Street Garden." I introduced myself to Jeannine and received her contact information.

After a zoom meeting with Jeannie Kiely, the founder of "Friends of Elizabeth Street Garden" at the community board meeting, I kept on contacting her and knew more information about the history of the site, current state of the lawsuit, and efforts community boards had made throughout the years of fighting. Furthermore, I proposed a possible solution after taking a closer look at the issue.

Back in 1822, according to a book named "History of Public-School Society (PSS) of the City of New York," it documented that "the pastor of the Bethel Baptist church applied to his trustees and requested them to erect a building for a school in Elizabeth Street. (Bourne, 1870)" Having the name of "school No. 5," the building is subject to charitable trust - a legally binding arrangement that donates assets to a charity or nonprofit for charitable purposes.

The next transfer of property right happened in 1853. As documented in the book of PSS history “The school property remained in the care of the Society until transferred to the Board of Education, in 1853. (Bourne, 1870)”

The area where Elizabeth Street is located, the Little Italy, is traditionally a neighborhood where generations of Italian immigrants have been proud to call home. According to a newspaper published back in 1974, an organization named “The Little Italy Restoration Association” had consulted with the Department of City Planning and proposed a plan in building a 600-pupil elementary school. (Fowler, 1976)

In 1981, a 151-unit building of federally subsidized apartments was built on one end of the parcel, leaving the adjacent 20000 square foot lot vacant until the city leased it for \$4,000 a month to Allan Reiver, the owner of an adjacent gallery. (New York Times, 2019) Allan Reiver transformed it into a garden and outdoor exhibition room for architectural garden ornaments. With two lion-shaped sculptures, lush parterres filled with vegetation, and comfortable chairs and tables for relaxation, the Elizabeth Street Garden sends forth an atmosphere of historical relics. That is the reason why the garden differs much from other open spaces. In 1990, according to a report by DNAinfo, the Allan got CB2’s support to lease the lot, where weeds are overgrown, and sculptures are stored. After a year has passed, Allan paid \$4000 to the city every month , planted vegetations in the garden, and maintained the garden. (Tcholakian, n.d.)

In 2012, the city council member Margret Chin proposed to make the lot as an affordable housing component to the Seward Park Urban Renewal Area (SPURA). This proposal, the starter of the twelve years fight against demolishing the garden, is later granted by the Department of Housing Preservation and Development (HPD) in 2012 (Colon, 2019). Claiming that SoHo area

needs more affordable housing and opportunities to let more people enjoy the area, Ms. Chin has a certain point of argument.

The conflicting issue placed the two most needed spaces - affordable housing and open recreational space – on the opposite sides of discussion. People standing against the demolition argues that even though creating affordable housing is a must-needed planning to the city, it should not be done at the sacrifice of the public garden. According to New York Times, the city plans to sell the land to build a seven-story, 123 apartment elevators building - Heaven Green - for low-income seniors owned by a construction company called “Penrose.” A rendered image by Haven Green of what the building and the surrounding environment will look like is pasted down below. Comparing to what I saw in the garden in real life, the view of the open space after the new construction lost its sense of history and sense of distilled time.

To have a better understanding of the issue, I went to the garden again to investigate on Oct 20th. I walked into the garden from the gate at Elizabeth Street. The other gate is located at



Mott Street at the opposite side of the block. I want to the garden in a lovely afternoon with dense people inside, so most of the sittings are occupied with downtown New Yorkers reading, talking, and online working. People love the garden, but the space is not enough.

Under such circumstance, getting rid of the garden and build a new senior affordable is going to post direct harm to the neighborhood’s quality of living. People including Martin Scorsese, Robert Denaro, and Kiki Smith had sent letters to the mayor. Putting the usefulness of these letters from celebrities aside, I agree to what Professor. Broderick said in a class that we

shouldn't be relying on special voices to vote for justice. In all, it should be a collective effort from the community.

During my visit to the Elizabeth Street Garden, I spoke with two volunteers stationed at a table near the entrance. After a brief introduction, I inquired about the current state of the legal efforts to preserve the garden. The volunteers were unable to provide new information beyond what is publicly available, as they are only permitted to discuss official updates published by the garden's administration. Nevertheless, I asked about an area in the garden that appeared unfurnished and filled with debris. They explained that, due to the financial strain of ongoing legal battles, the garden lacks sufficient funding to repair and maintain this section. Consequently, the area remains in disrepair.



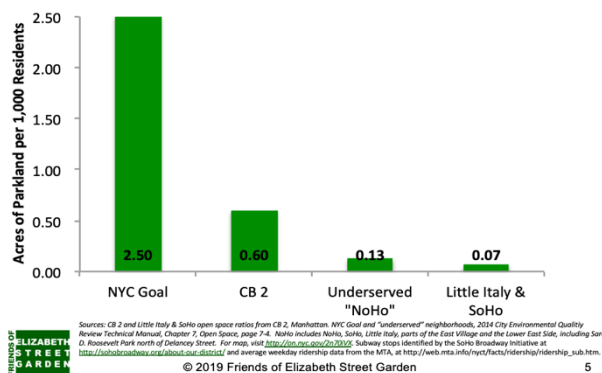
The potential destruction of Elizabeth Street Garden threatens not only the community but also the prosperity of nearby businesses and organizations. An open letter to Mayor Eric Adams hosted on the garden's official website, highlights that the garden draws over a thousand visitors each week, offering significant economic benefits to local businesses. Described as a "unique green oasis" amid the dense urban landscape, the garden serves as both an artistic space and a popular spot for residents and tourists. As of November 6, 2024, a total of 222 organizations and businesses have signed this letter in support of preserving the garden.

During my October 30 visit to nearby businesses, I spoke with locals about their perspectives. At "Lovely Day," a Thai restaurant located a street away from the garden, I spoke

with an employee named Claire. She explained that Lovely Day signed the open letter, adding, “I go to the garden every day before and after work, and so does the owner of this restaurant. She walks her dog in the garden every morning.” Claire also noted the “symbiotic” relationship between the shop and the garden, suggesting that each brings foot traffic to the other.

I also visited “Maguire,” a nearby clothing store, and spoke to the owner, Debb. She shared that while she had signed the letter, she harbored mixed feelings. “I know that maybe the construction of affordable housing could bring me more customers,” she said, “but I’m worried that the sun will be blocked even more. Right now, the buildings nearby already shade the area in the afternoon—I don’t want all the sunlight to disappear.” Her words underscored the broader sentiment: that losing the garden would impact not just residents but the entire local ecosystem of businesses, challenging both the neighborhood’s character and economic liveliness.

Inside a report shared with me from Jeannie, I read a diagram describing acres of parkland per 1,000 residents in relationship to different areas in New York. It is concluded that the Acres of Parkland per 1,000 residents for areas inside CB2 is significantly lower than NYC’s goal. The garden, unfortunately, is in the only downtown neighborhood that NYC Parks defines



as underserved by open space. Little Italy & SoHo have even less open space – open space ratio of 0.07 or 3 square foot per person, equalizing to the size of a subway seat. While exploring the Lower East Side and Little Italy, I observed that there are few

alternative sites where residents can relax and spend leisure time. One such site is the Dorothy Strelsin Memorial Garden at 174 Suffolk Street (illustrated in the photo on the right), a small rectangular garden that offers a similar sense of tranquility. Visitors there were engaged in



activities like meditation and reading. However, this garden is only about one-third the size of the Elizabeth Street Garden, making it insufficient to accommodate large gatherings or public events due to limited space.

Jeannie also explained to me the bigger and better alternative for another construction site of the affordable house: the 388 Hudson. At that side, five times as much housing could be established, and the garden wouldn't have to be destroyed. Officially named the "Win-Win proposal," it's proposed by the Council member Christopher Marte. A funding transfer from Haven Green, in collaboration with up-zonings from the Council, can realize up to approximately 705 new affordable housing units and preserve Elizabeth Street Garden. However, the suggestion was not accepted immediately, but after 6 years. According to an interview with Joseph Reiver whose father Allan Reiver was the creator of the garden, he said that: "they started making plans to build on it recently after wasting six years. And then the other sites, they've also said similar dismissive things. Maybe



they will start building on them too, who knows. (Nevins, 2024)" On the left side is a photograph of 388 Hudson, which is still an open ground garage.

As for the current state of the garden till October 29th, according to Architectural Record, an order is enacted to vacate the property was issued for September 10, but the garden, facing significant challenges, was granted an additional two weeks when an appeals court judge suspended the eviction notice. It now has permission to stay open until at least October 30 (Schulman, 2024). As the new deadline approaches, the future of the garden remains uncertain. On November 2nd, advocates of Elizabeth Street Garden claims that their eviction has been paused pending an appeal, which means that the case is currently scheduled for February 2025 (Houlis, 2024).

In conclusion, the Elizabeth Street Garden stands as a rare and cherished green space in a densely populated area of New York City with both historical and cultural value. It provides both a landmark and a recreational haven for the community. This ongoing dispute over its potential demolition and redevelopment reflects broader challenges in the process of urban planning, where the need for affordable housing shall be balanced with preserving public spaces that contribute to both the residents' quality of life and the prosperity of the businesses and organizations adjacent to the site. Despite advocacy from prominent individuals, local businesses, and community groups, the garden's future remains uncertain as it faces impending legal and political obstacles few months later. This case highlights the importance of inclusive community decision-making and the need for sustainable solutions that address multiple needs from people without sacrificing one for the other. Furthermore, the proposed alternative site at 388 Hudson presents a viable "win-win" solution, underscoring the possibility of constructive collaboration between housing and preservation goals. As the community continues to advocate

for the garden, its fate rests on the outcomes of the upcoming appeals, leaving the future of this unique green oasis in question.

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